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Conflict Management
Conflict as a Part of Life

Introduction: The Dynamics of Conflict

We all know from experience that conflict is a part of life. At work, at home with our family, in our local neighborhood, or with friends, the seed of conflict is everywhere. Human nature seems doomed to conflict. We all dread its consequences: colleagues who detest one another, family members who are no longer on speaking terms, neighbors who trade insults, friends who turn into enemies. Is conflict really all bad, though?

Sometimes, conflict can increase people's self-knowledge, intrinsic motivation and ability to learn. Sociologists such as Max Weber and George Simmel maintain that disagreement is essential to the development of culture, and that airing differences fosters creativity and healthy interpersonal relations. Other contemporary sociologists, such as Lewis Coser, argue that a certain amount of conflict is necessary in groups, as groups need both harmony and discord.[1] Does that mean conflict is a good thing?

Conflict may certainly be a good thing, provided it has a real basis and stays within limits. Gratuitous, unnecessary conflict, however, benefits nobody. Although disagreements may be enriching, they should not be allowed to escalate into confrontation or mutely persist as a conformity. Conflict is a part of life, but it is dynamic, not static. It goes through different phases. The effects may be positive or negative, depending on how it is managed. If the situation slips out of control, the costs will far outweigh the benefits, if there are any.

Because conflict has its own dynamic, we need to understand how that dynamic operates. To start with, we must distinguish two dimensions of conflict: rational and emotional. Rational conflict is based on disagreement over some objective issue and tends to be explicit. Emotional

[1] On the positive effects of conflict and the views of some contemporary sociologists, see Perlow, Leslie A., *When You Say Yes But Mean No*, Crown Business, 2003.

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conflict, by contrast, operates on a personal level: the parties feel hurt and break off relations (though they may continue seeing one another). The interaction of these two planes gives the following possibilities:[2]

		Rational	
		Disagreement	**Agreement**
Emotional	**Agreement**	Discrepancy	Unity
	Disagreement	Confrontation	Conformity

Unity – i.e., rational and emotional agreement – seems unproblematic in principle. Unity seems a natural goal for a work team. However, *discrepancy* – i.e., rational disagreement on specific issues, without emotional conflict – is desirable, because it tends to be productive and enriching. Discrepancy can stimulate problem-solving skills, creativity, motivation and team cohesion. However, they are effective only if they lead to a new unity. Thus, the unity-discrepancy-unity dynamic is positive and *must not be blocked.*

The problem is when a discrepancy remains unresolved and emotional harmony breaks down, leading to *confrontation.* When differences are taken personally, the parties become opponents. Situations of rational and emotional disagreement are very stressful and, therefore, unstable: either the relationship ceases to exist, or the confrontation is conducted to a discrepancy, or the parties make a conformity. In other words, to avoid a complete break, the parties must either stop taking the conflict personally and steer the dispute back toward the ground of rational disagreement *(discrepancy)*, or else they must resort to a superficially rational agreement to ignore and cover up the emotional conflict between them *(conformity)*. It is important, therefore, to try to erect a barrier between discrepancy and confrontation, so that the former does not degenerate into the latter. And if it does, we must quickly convert confrontation back into mere discrepancy.

We now need to consider how to deal with a conformity. As a conformity in fact conceals a confrontation, the only way to get beyond it is to recognize the latent confrontation or threat of break-up. Once we have acknowledged that rational and emotional disagreement persists, we will be able to try to heal the emotional wounds and steer the situation toward discrepancy. It does not appear to be possible to go directly from a situation of conformity to one of unity.

To summarize, conflict is a dynamic phenomenon that moves between two planes: rational and emotional. The quest for agreement therefore also follows a certain dynamic. To find the keys to conflict management we therefore feel it important to organize the discussion as follows. First, we shall explore the potential causes of conflict and how to prevent pointless conflict. Secondly, we shall suggest ways to resolve rational conflict constructively. And thirdly, we shall consider ways to resolve emotional conflict constructively.

[2] On the rational and emotional dimension and the dynamic of conflict, see Cardona, Pablo and Pilar García-Lombardía, *Cómo desarrollar las competencias de liderazgo*, EUNSA, 2005. (The figure showing the two planes is on page 168.)

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Potential Causes of Conflict

Understanding the potential sources of conflict can help us manage conflict. The causes of conflict can be divided into three large groups: personal differences, human tendencies that favor conflict, and contextual factors. After examining these causes, we shall suggest some ways to deal with or prevent pointless conflict and some attitudes that can help deal with any kind of conflict.

A) Personal Differences

Interpersonal conflicts often are rooted in differences between individuals. Broadly, the differences may be of four types, which we shall briefly analyze.

1) Differences of Gender, Beliefs, Values, Culture and Taste

First, the male-female difference influences how we see things and therefore how we deal with them. Men and women see things differently. In *Men are from Mars, Women are from Venus*, John Gray uses examples from daily life to illustrate the psychological differences (rooted in anthropological differences) between men and women.

Secondly, our perception of reality is strongly influenced by our beliefs, values and culture, as these play a crucial role in the formation of personality. Usually, they are anchored in our earliest upbringing and experience. Precisely because our beliefs, values and culture are anchored in our personality, we may find it very difficult to come to terms with people whose beliefs, values and culture are different from our own.

Lastly, tastes may not be as decisive as gender, beliefs, values or culture, yet differences of taste can still be a major source of irritation between people, as they usually affect daily habits.

2) Differences of Personality

Social psychology has identified four basic tendencies in the way people approach reality and interpersonal relations: rational, conceptual, sensitive and emotional.[3] The following diagram helps to visualize this:

	Senses	**Intuition**
Thought	Rational	Conceptual
Feeling	Sensitive	Emotional

Let's talk about this figure:

A "rational" person tends to concentrate on the facts, the "*what*," the objective information he obtains from his senses. He decides on the basis of that objective information, following strictly

[3] These four personality types were observed by Katharine C. Briggs and Isabel Briggs Myers. Between them they developed an intelligence test, known as MBTI (Myers-Briggs Type Indicators), which can be used to identify a person's dominant personality type. The four types are the result of different combinations of senses versus intuition and thought versus feeling. For explanations of the various combinations and their impact on personal management style, see Benfari, Robert, *Changing your Management Style*, Lexington Books, 1995 (particularly the first chapter).

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logical rules. A "conceptual" person follows his intuition and thoughts. Before deciding or doing anything, he wants to know the "*why*," the ultimate reason. He needs to see the big picture and know what he is aiming for. A "sensitive" person focuses on the information he receives from his senses and decides based on feelings or emotions relating to the environment. He is concerned about the "*how*," the details and the organization. His sensitivity enables him to detect hidden feelings that others are unaware of. The "emotional" person intuits and feels, focusing on people, on the "*who*." He is communicative, a natural politician.

We must beware of simplifying, however: nobody belongs entirely to one type or another. As a rule, we all have a bit of each, though usually one predominates. All the same, it is easy to see that these tendencies can be a source of conflict. For instance, a "sensitive" person may find a "rational" person's view of the world and way of relating to those around him hurtful and intolerable.

3) Differences of Education and Experience

Two people with different upbringing and different experience may find it difficult to communicate. When we talk, or even when we try to convey a message without words, we take it for granted that the other person will understand what we mean. But someone whose education and experience is very different from ours may well misinterpret what we mean. One need only think of the common misunderstandings in companies between the sales department and the production department.

4) Differences of Needs and Resources

We all have certain goals and tasks to complete and certain constraints of time, budget and rank. Our needs are great and our resources limited, and sometimes our needs and resources may clash with those of others. Continuing with our previous example, the sales department usually has very different priorities from the production department, and vice versa, but the two departments need each other, so it is not surprising there should be confrontations.

B) Human Tendencies that Favor Conflict

This refers to certain important limitations that are common to all human beings and that greatly hinder interpersonal communication. The limitations are:

1) Pride. Pride is an excessive opinion of one's own worth. It can lead us to think ourselves superior to others. It can make us deaf to other people's views, as we are so convinced we are right. Pride may also prevent us from giving in, as we do not want to lose.

2) Envy. Envy is the tendency to feel sad because someone else is better off than we are. Envy directly influences our perceptions of justice and injustice in interpersonal relations.

3) Laziness. Laziness is an aversion to work, a general slowness of behavior and lack of interest. Not doing what we are supposed to do when we are supposed to do it can lead to major conflicts.

4) Indifference. Indifference is a lack of interest in others. It may be due to selfishness, or to insensitivy resulting from childood upbringing and experience.

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5) Tendency to judge other people. This refers to the tendency to label people according to a few rigid criteria. Our judgments of a person can create an invisible barrier between us. Even if we never tell the other person what we think, he will very likely sense it. By labeling a person, we greatly reduce the scope for understanding and communicating with that person in the future. This tendency to judge others goes hand in hand with a tendency to look for someone to blame and treat people unfairly.

6) Fear of confrontation. This is a fear of facing up to reality, because of the consequences. Having seen or actually experienced how badly some conflicts end, we prefer not to talk about conflict or pretend, even to ourselves, that it does not exist or is not important. We may also dislike the feeling of "being exposed" if we reveal our feelings, for fear of being thought weak or fragile. This means that not all the cards are on the table, which makes it more likely we will be disappointed.

C) Contextual Factors

Next, we shall consider some causes of conflict that are rooted in circumstances:

1) Organizational structure. Some organizational designs may favor conflict. The strong interdependence between departments is a good example.

2) Meeting duration and design. Marathon meetings, without breaks, lead to fatigue and irritability. Similarly, not having a fixed agenda or not dealing with issues systematically can cause distraction and confusion, which may lead to conflict.[4]

3) Task and goal assignment. Needless to say, it would be unrealistic to expect to be able to define exactly where every task begins and ends, and who is responsible for it. In a company, every job is related to every other, and to some extent all jobs overlap. Nevertheless, there are clear limits, and when those limits are not respected, conflict is difficult to avoid. Whatever tasks and goals we assign should be "SMART," that is, specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and time-bound.[5]

4) States of mind. We all have our ups and downs, due to tiredness, stress, good or bad news, or personal frustrations or successes. Our states of mind radiate positive or negative feelings: a flow of negative feelings makes conflict more likely.

In summary, there are many possible reasons why conflicts may occur. Knowing the dangers will help us prevent pointless or gratuitous conflicts. We shall now see how to do that.

How to Prevent Pointless Conflicts

Disagreements are good, but only if there is a point to them, not if they are gratuitous and senseless. It would be foolish to underestimate the danger of confrontation. When do pointless

[4] Rodríguez Porras recommends setting time limits for meetings and making short breaks. He also recommends sticking to a pre-established agenda and agreed rules of debate. Rodríguez Porras, José Ma., *Relaciones humanas en la empresa*, Ediciones Internacionales Universitarias, 2005.

[5] See Cardona, Pablo and Pilar García-Lombardía, op. cit., page 114.

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disagreements usually arise? When one or both of the parties does not have the basic information or criteria needed to make a decision:

- The relevant facts.
- The problem and/or its causes.
- The decision criteria.
- The possible alternatives.

It is important to stress that such disagreements are very difficult to resolve, because the parties are not talking about the same thing. Reaching a consensus or agreement is therefore more complicated. To reduce the scope for unnecessary conflict, we suggest:

1) Take differences into account. We have to accept that we are different and that we see things differently.
2) Listen. Only if we listen carefully will we be able to understand why other people think and act as they do.
3) Ask. Asking questions helps the other person express his thoughts more clearly, which benefits both parties.
4) Paraphrase. Repeating out loud what the other person has said helps to make sure you have understood exactly what he intended to communicate.
5) Adopt constructive inner attitudes. We will find it easier to respond constructively to any conflict if we adopt certain inner attitudes:
    a) Humility. Humility helps us understand other people and not judge them too harshly or rashly, and to accept our own limitations and those of others.
    b) Genuine interest in people. Show real concern for others and their professional and personal development.
    c) Diligence. We must do promptly what we are supposed to do, so that nobody suffers because of our neglect.
    d) Put things in perspective. Sometimes we need to pull back, find time for ourselves and put our thoughts and feelings in order, so as to see things in perspective and not lose sight of the greater whole.
    e) Strive to improve, not necessarily to be the best. If we do that, we will free ourselves of much of the stress that cripples the mind and the ability to respond, and so be better able to react constructively to conflict.

So far we have considered the causes of conflict and how to avoid pointless conflicts. Now, we shall discuss how to resolve conflicts. First, we shall consider how to resolve rational conflict, and then emotional conflict.

How to Resolve Rational Conflict Constructively

Some disagreements have good reasons and must be accepted as an opportunity to find a better solution to the problem in question. In such cases, we must seek agreement constructively, so

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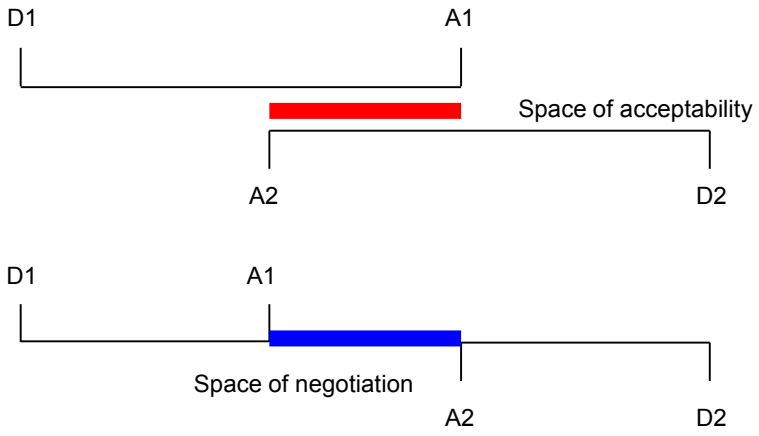
that the discrepancy is resolved on the rational plane, without encroaching on the emotional plane. The following is a brief guide.

1) State your differences and, if necessary, your feelings constructively. Any statement of opinion should be based on objective information and should be designed to produce understanding, not confrontation. Feelings should be expressed calmy, without hostility. We may have certain inner barriers that prevent us from communicating differences and feelings constructively: mental rigidity, indecision, meddlesomeness or coldness.[6] We should analyze any such barriers and try to remove them.

2) Make a clear distinction between what we would ideally like and what we would be prepared to accept. Our natural tendency is to think in terms of our ideal solution. If there is a difference of opinion, however, we should decide what would be acceptable to us, even if it is less than ideal. We need to be able to explain our ideal, what would be acceptable to us, and what would not (and why not). If the other party does the same, we may be able to find some common ground. If not, we will have to turn to negotiation. Figure 1 helps to visualize what we have been saying:

Figure 1

(A: Acceptable, D: Ideal, A1: Person 1, A2: Person 2)



3) Negotiate. To negotiate is basically to seek agreement by making concessions on either side. There are different combinations:

   a) Win/win. Here the aim is to solve the problem in a creative way, so that both sides gain. This is the natural goal of all negotiation. But it is not always easy or even possible to find a creative solution of this kind.

   b) Win/lose. This outcome makes sense if your position of authority forces you to take responsibility for a decision, possibly even for the other person's good. It is typical of the boss-subordinate relationship, as sometimes the boss's opinion must prevail.

[6] See Kindler, Herbert S., *Cómo gestionar los conflictos*, Editorial Centro de Estudios Ramón Areces, 1998.

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c) Lose/win. Here, sacrifice is seen as a long-term gain that strengthens the relationship. At bottom, it is a sign of maturity and relationship quality.

d) Lose/lose. This is clearly an outcome to be avoided. If the negotiation seems deadlocked, it is best to seek mediation or arbitration, which we shall discuss later.

We should not assume that only one or two of these combinations are optimal. In negotiations, *the winner does not always win, nor the loser always lose.*

How to Resolve Emotional Conflict Constructively

What is it, ultimately, that sparks a confrontation? Emotional disagreement. The difference of opinion is accompanied by other manifestations: angry looks, unkind words, overwrought gestures, unspoken but keenly felt criticisms, humiliating comparisons... The parties take the discrepancy as a personal affront and lose sight of the original problem. The resulting virulent dynamic leads to a process of emotionally destructive feedback. In this process, one or more of the following emotional reactions may occur:

	Negative	Positive
Proactive	It's not my fault	I'll get you back
Reactive	You are a @ *!!	About time too

For example, if one person feels offended and starts to denigrate the other or proffer insults such as "you're a @ *!!," the other is more likely to react with excuses such as "it's not my fault" or "it's nothing to get angry about," instead of saying "I'm sorry." Moreover, without a sincere apology, the offended person may harbor resentment and promise himself that he will "get back" at the one who offended him. If an apology is eventually forthcoming, it is likely to be met with an unforgiving "About time too."

The negative consequences of an emotionally destructive feedback dynamic are easy to imagine. So how can we deal constructively with confrontation?

1) Give emotionally constructive feedback. Conflicts would be much less frequent and much less virulent if only we could learn to give emotionally constructive feedback. The basic types of emotionally constructive feedback are:

	Negative	Positive
Proactive	I'm sorry	Never mind
Reactive	I feel hurt	Thank you

A reconciliation process would use one or more of the constructive feedback mechanisms listed above. For example, it is important to be able to say, "I feel hurt," rather than letting the emotional hurt turn into aggressive hostility to the other person. A mature reaction would then be to say, "I'm sorry." To make a sincere apology we must:

- Accept any mistake we may have made.

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- Think seriously about what caused it.
- Be genuinely willing to change, so as not to hurt the other person again.
- Say "I'm sorry" and mean it.
- Repair the damage if possible.
- Make some gesture to reinforce the damaged relationship.

Following the same dynamic, the other person must be capable of saying, "never mind." That may not be easy, particularly if the apology is not very convincing. In that case, one may calmly ask the other person to be more sincere. Lastly, reconciliation requires the "never mind." Otherwise, the conflict may harden and crystallize, guaranteeing permanent emotional dissatisfaction for both parties. Lastly, after the "never mind," there has to be a heartfelt "thank you." What happens if this sequence of emotionally constructive feedback is interrupted at any point and there is silence?

Silence is not emotionally indifferent. There is a mature and necessary silence in every relationship. But there is also a silence that hides an immature and destructive attitude. This is what we mean by emotional silence. The following diagram shows the causes and consequences of emotional silence in conflict management.

Emotional silence	
Causes	**Consequences**
Pride	Distrust
Insensitivity	Revenge/insensitivity
Avoidance of conflict	Conflict worsens
Revenge	Insensitivity/revenge

Consequently, we must avoid emotional silence if we want to turn a conflict situation around. Otherwise, we may never get to the end of the emotionally constructive feedback process: the "never mind" and the "thank you." If we do complete the process, we will have found the way to defuse the confrontation and turn it back into a discrepancy. That is not always possible, however. If the feedback process fails, we will have to seek outside help to resolve the conflict.

2) Outside help. If the parties are unable to agree, they will have to seek outside help. The wound caused by the conflict refuses to heal, so steps must be taken to control the emotional damage. The following types of outside help are available:

   a) Mediation. Mediation consists of seeking consensus through a third party. This third party must be someone whose authority and prestige both parties accept. The mediator may convey messages between the parties and chair a face-to-face *meeting* (or confrontation). At all times, the mediator must remember these basic rules:

      - Find out how the conflict started: the key issues and the sources of disagreement.
      - Hear both sides.

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- Try to understand clearly each side's perceptions and feelings.[7]
- Examine the conditions and circumstances that sustain the conflict.
- Do not take sides.

b) Arbitration. Arbitration can be defined as official mediation. The parties undertake to decide in accordance with rules laid down by a neutral third party: the arbitrator. A mediator, by contrast, could be a common friend or acquaintance.

c) Counseling. Counseling, in this context, refers to specialist help in analyzing and dealing with the repercussions of conflict. Nowadays, many married couples turn to a counselor to advise them how to behave toward one another. Similarly, counselors may be asked to help people deal with interpersonal conflicts at work.

d) Separation. Understood as physical separation. Sometimes it may be best simply to avoid physical contact with the other person as far as possible and instead communicate by internal mail, for example. The superior of the two parties in conflict could choose to separate them physically, or else separate their functions, so that they no longer have to deal with one another so directly. Separation is sometimes the lesser evil and allows a measure of inner peace and freedom.

e) Courts. Taking a matter to court is a last resort to be avoided if at all possible. But there may come a time when it is the only way to resolve a conflict, when all other options have failed.

3) Termination of relationship. Terminating the relationship puts an end to the conflict and avoids any contact between the parties. Sometimes, this is not simple: unless we actually leave the company, we may find it difficult to avoid the other person who still works in it.

Summing up, we have analyzed different ways of reacting to emotional conflict. If what we want is an emotionally mature reconciliation, we will have to follow some of the basic rules to establish an emotionally constructive feedback process. Failing that, we will have to seek outside help. Ultimately, we may have to terminate our relationship. Whatever happens, we must always show respect for the other person and act fairly.

Conflict will always be a part of life. We humans are complex and conflict-prone. The important thing is how we manage conflict. In this note we have considered what causes conflict, how it can be prevented, and how we can react constructively to it on the rational and the emotional plane. Our attempts at analysis and dissection will never capture the whole of reality. Yet we believe they may serve as a practical guide.

[7] See Ware, James and Louis B. Barnes, "Managing Interpersonal Conflict," technical note, Harvard Business School, 1978.

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Recommended Reading

- Cardona, Pablo and Pilar García-Lombardía, *Cómo desarrollar las competencias de liderazgo*, EUNSA, 2005.
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